

COGS 50.04 • THEORIES OF CONSCIOUSNESS

Fall 2025

Instructor:	Caleb Kendrick	Time:	TuTh 10:00 – 12:00
Office:	Raven 105	X:	F 3:30 – 4:20
Email:	caleb.kendrick@dartmouth.edu	Place:	TBD

Objectives: This course provides an overview of contemporary debates concerning the relationship between “access” and “phenomenal” consciousness. We will survey a wide range of theories including the global workspace theory, recurrent process theory, higher-order thought (HOT) theory, and Block’s fragile short-term memory theory. We will also examine recent experimental work employing the “no-report” paradigm which attempts to isolate the neural correlates of consciousness using physiological measures rather than participant self-reports.

Course materials: The readings from this class will consist of journal articles and portions of three books. I will provide PDFs of all the course materials. However, since we will be referencing them often, you may consider purchasing these books:

Dehaene, Stanislas (2014). *Consciousness and the Brain: Deciphering How the Brain Codes Our Thoughts*. Viking Adult.

Carruthers, Peter (2019). *Human and Animal Minds: The Consciousness Questions Laid to Rest*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press.

Block, Ned (2023). *The Border Between Seeing and Thinking*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press.

Grading:

- Presentations, quizzes and other assignments(20%)
- 2 response papers ($\approx$ 500 words) (20%)
- 1 short paper (4-6 pp double-spaced) (25%)
- Final paper or project (8-10 pages for an individual; 12-15 page for a group) (25%)
- Attendance and class participation: (10%)

Important Dates:

Short paper dueDue TBD
Final paper or project due Due TBD

Academic Honesty: The faculty, administration, and students of Dartmouth College acknowledge the responsibility to maintain and perpetuate the principle of academic honor, and recognize that any instance of academic dishonesty is considered a violation of the [Academic Honor Principle](#).

Religious Accommodations: Dartmouth has a deep commitment to support students' religious observances and diverse faith practices. Some students may wish to take part in religious observances that occur during this academic term. If you have a religious observance that conflicts with your participation in the course, please meet with me as soon as possible—before the end of the second week of the term at the latest—to discuss appropriate course adjustments.

Disability Accommodations: Students requesting disability-related accommodations and services for this course are required to register with Student Accessibility Services (SAS; [Apply for Services](#); student.accessibility.services@dartmouth.edu; 1-603-646-9900) and to request that an accommodation email be sent to me in advance of the need for an accommodation. Then, students should schedule a follow-up meeting with me to determine relevant details such as what role SAS or its [Testing Center](#) may play in accommodation implementation. This process works best for everyone when completed as early in the quarter as possible. If students have questions about whether they are eligible for accommodations or have concerns about the implementation of their accommodations, they should contact the SAS office. All inquiries and discussions will remain confidential.

Mental Health Resources: The academic environment is challenging, our terms are intensive, and classes are not the only demanding part of your life. There are a number of resources available to you on campus to support your wellness, including: the [Counseling Center](#) which allows you to book triage appointments online, the [Student Wellness Center](#) which offers wellness check-ins, and your [undergraduate dean](#). The student-led [Dartmouth Student Mental Health Union](#) and their peer support program may be helpful if you would like to speak to a trained fellow student support listener. If you need immediate assistance, please contact the counselor on-call at (603) 646-9442 at any time. Please make me aware of anything that will hinder your success in this course.

Sexual and Gender-Based Misconduct: At Dartmouth, we value integrity, responsibility, and respect for the rights and interests of others, all central to our Principles of Community. We are dedicated to establishing and maintaining a safe and inclusive campus where all community members have equal access to Dartmouth's educational and employment opportunities. We strive to promote an environment of sexual respect, safety, and well-being. Through the Sexual and Gender-Based Misconduct Policy (SMP), Dartmouth demonstrates that sex and gender-based discrimination, sex and gender-based harassment, sexual assault, dating violence, domestic violence, stalking, etc., are not tolerated in our community.

For more information regarding Title IX and to access helpful resources, visit Title IX's website (sexual-respect.dartmouth.edu). As a faculty member, I am required to share disclosures of sexual or gender-based misconduct with the Title IX office.

If you have any questions or want to explore support and assistance, please contact the Title IX office at 603-646-0922 or TitleIX@dartmouth.edu. Speaking to Title IX does not automatically initiate a college resolution. Instead, much of their work is around providing supportive measures to ensure you can continue to engage in Dartmouth's programs and activities.

Financial Hardship Resources: If you encounter financial challenges related to this class, there may be sources of support for you. If you feel comfortable sharing your experience with me, you may. You may also consider meeting with a financial aid officer to discuss options, reaching out to the First-Generation Office if you are a first-generation student, browsing the [Funding Resources](#) page, or, for unexpected expenses, applying to the Barrier Removal Fund through the Financial Aid tile in [DartHub](#).

Tentative Course Outline:

| Preliminaries

Nagel, Thomas (1974). What is it like to be a bat? *Philosophical Review* 83 (October):435-50.

Jackson, Frank (1982). Epiphenomenal qualia. *Philosophical Quarterly* 32 (April):127-136.

Harman, Gilbert (1990). The intrinsic quality of experience. *Philosophical Perspectives* 4:31-52.

Chapter 1 sections 1.1 to 1.4 of Carruthers (2019).

| Access vs. phenomenal consciousness

Block, Ned (1995). On a confusion about a function of consciousness. *Brain and Behavioral Sciences* 18 (2):227–247.

Chapter 1 sections 1.5 to 1.8 of Carruthers (2019).

| The “easy” and “hard” problems of consciousness

Chalmers, David (1995). Facing up to the problem of consciousness. *Journal of Consciousness Studies* 2 (3):200-19.

| The global workspace theory

Baars, Bernard J. (1997). In the theatre of consciousness: Global workspace theory, a rigorous scientific theory of consciousness. *Journal of Consciousness Studies* 4 (4):292-309.

Dennett, Daniel (2001). Are we explaining consciousness yet? *Cognition* 79(1-2):221-237.

Chapters 5 & 6 of Carruthers (2019).

| The global neuronal workspace theory

Dehaene, Stanislas & Lionel Naccache (2001). Towards a cognitive neuroscience of consciousness: basic evidence and a workspace framework. *Cognition* 79(1-2): 1-37.

| The recurrent processing theory

Lamme, Victor A. (2006). Towards a true neural stance on consciousness. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences* 10(11):494-501.

| The higher-order theory

Rosenthal, David M. (1986). Two concepts of consciousness. *Philosophical Studies* 49 (May):329-59.

Lau, Hakwan, and David Rosenthal (2011). Empirical support for higher-order theories of conscious awareness. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences* 15(8): 365-373.

Chapter 4 section 4.4 in Carruthers (2019).

Chapter 13 sections titled “High order thought” and “Alleged evidence for higher order thought theories” of Block (2023).

| Fragile short-term memory and the “overflow” argument

Block, Ned (2007). Consciousness, accessibility, and the mesh between psychology and neuroscience. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences* 30(5–6):481–548.

Block, Ned (2011). Perceptual consciousness overflows cognitive access. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences* 15 (12):567-575.

Cohen, Michael A., & Daniel C. Dennett (2011). Consciousness cannot be separated from function. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences* 15 (8): 358–64.

Phillips, Ian B. (2011). Perception and iconic memory: what Sperling doesn't show. *Mind and Language* 26 (4):381-411.

Cohen, Michael A., Dennett, Daniel C., & Kanwisher, Nancy (2016). What is the bandwidth of perceptual experience? *Trends in Cognitive Sciences* 20(5): 324-335.

Chapter 4 section 4.3 of Carruthers (2019).

Binocular rivalry and the “no-report” paradigm

Tsuchiya, N., Wilke, M., Frässle, S., & Lamme, V. A. (2015). No-report paradigms: extracting the true neural correlates of consciousness. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences* 19(12): 757-770.

Block, Ned (2019). What is wrong with the no-report paradigm and how to fix it. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences* 23 (12):1003-1013.

Phillips, Ian & Jorge Morales (2020). The fundamental problem with no-cognition paradigms. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences* 24(3):165-167.

Read Chapter 2 section titled “Rivalry” and Chapter 7 of Block (2023).

Is phenomenal consciousness an illusion?

Frankish, Keith (2016). Illusionism as a theory of consciousness. *Journal of Consciousness Studies* 23 (11-12):11-39.

Schwitzgebel, Eric (2016). Phenomenal consciousness, defined and defended as innocently as I can manage. *Journal of Consciousness Studies* 23 (11-12):224-235.